New Delhi were free to engage Iran on the basis of their own, and not Washington's, policy interests. Rivalry between Beijing and New Delhi quickly emerged. Once Beijing and New Delhi concluded that their vital ties with the United States were no longer endangered by moving closer to Tehran, both China and India began bidding for Iran's favour. Intensified Sino–Indian rivalry in Iran was an unintended consequence of the recession of US power asserted against Iran. Another simpler way of saying this is that Beijing and New Delhi both saw an emerging power vacuum created by US retreat, and both moved to "fill" that vacuum.

Third, when compelled to disengage from Iran for the sake of placating Washington, China seems to have done a better job than India did of protecting its political investment in Iran. Although this author has not undertaken a close comparison of Chinese and Indian tactics for limiting Iranian anger over their respective capitulations to American pressure, my impression is that Beijing was more adept at finding other ways of helping Iran when abandoning ways too objectionable to Washington. For example, when Beijing withdrew from nuclear cooperation with Iran in 1997 under intense US pressure and as part of a broad-gauged effort to re-normalise US–PRC relations after the upheavals of 1989–1996, Beijing resisted US pressure until it had already transferred a critical uranium hexafluoride plant to China. Beijing also assuaged Iranian anger over China's "capitulation" to US pressure by becoming Iran's key protector in International Atomic Energy Agency and UN Security Council debates over Iran's nuclear programmes.[4] A more recent example of China's efforts to protect its relation with Tehran even while submitting to US demands to approve further Security Council resolutions and cut purchases of Iranian oil was Beijing's intense and high-profile mediation effort at the Seven Party Talks. Even while acceding to American demands to pressure Tehran, China found ways to demonstrate to Tehran that China stood with Iran.